DDN

GLOBAL GTM SOLUTION ENGINEERING CENTRE OF EXCELLENCE

CANDIDATE CHALLENGE

CoE RFP Manager

Madrid

Second-stage challenge brief

Before you begin
Please read this brief together with the attached “DDN Context Fact Sheet”. Plan for approximately 12 hours of preparation over one week.

We are interested in how you think, what you build and the choices you make. There is no single right answer.

Why this round

We want to see how you think and how you build, in the way you would actually work in this role. There is no single right answer. We are interested in the choices you make, why you make them and what you decide to leave out.

The scenario

It is your first week as DDN's CoE RFP Manager. There is no dedicated RFP function today: Solution Engineers (SEs) answer RFPs and RFIs alongside their deal work, with little shared content and no common way of deciding which bids deserve the most effort.

> **Your mandate**
> Build that function: AI-first, practical and designed in a way the field will actually want to use.

THREE PARTS

What to prepare

A. 30 / 90 / 180-day plan

Set out your priorities, key actions and concrete deliverables for each period, and explain how you would scope the function.

- Which RFPs the function owns end-to-end, which it supports and which the field handles with self-service tools, including how bid / no-bid and level-of-effort decisions are made.
- What the function does not take on, and how you protect that boundary.
- How you work with field SEs, account teams and specialist contributors such as product, security and legal: hand-offs, review and sign-off.
- How response content is sourced, owned and kept current.
- How you would measure success, and what you would do in your first 30 days to establish a baseline.

B. A prototype you built yourself, demoed live

Build something that makes RFP / RFI responses faster or better. The choice is yours. Examples include:

- Drafting answers from a knowledge base with sources.
- Turning a tender into a requirements or compliance matrix.
- Scoring bid / no-bid decisions.
- Reviewing a draft for gaps and win themes.

PART B

Prototype guidance

Data

Use DDN's public material, including the fact sheet, product pages, documentation and customer success stories, together with a publicly available tender or a questionnaire you write yourself. Typical sections may include technical architecture, performance, security / InfoSec, support and commercial terms.

What to explain

- Where the prototype helps most and where it breaks.
- How a human reviews the output.
- How you would handle wrong or outdated answers.
- What it would take to run on real volumes.

How finished should it be?

It does not need to be production-ready. It should work on a small, realistic example and make your idea tangible. Parts may be simplified, hard-coded or mocked, provided you explain which parts and why. A rough prototype that works beats a polished mock-up.

> **Builder expectation**
> AI-assisted coding counts as building it yourself, as long as you can explain how it works and why you built it that way. Bring a short screen recording as a back-up in case of technical issues.

C. Vision beyond year one

Close your presentation with a short view of where the RFP function could be beyond year one: how AI and self-service change the role of the team and the field SE, and how the function helps DDN win more of the deals it chooses to pursue. This is a closing section, not a separate document.

Timebox and scope

Plan for about 12 hours of preparation over the week. We mean it: we assess the quality of your scoping decisions, not the hours spent. Tell us briefly what you chose not to do and why; that is part of the assessment.

Plan	Approximately 4 hours on the 30 / 90 / 180-day plan.
Prototype	Approximately 6 hours on a small, realistic working example.
Deck + rehearsal	Approximately 2 hours on the presentation and rehearsal.

These timings are a guide only. We do not expect equal depth on every point in part A; prioritise.

Format and submission

- Language: English.
- Presentation: approximately 10–12 slides in PowerPoint, Google Slides or PDF.
- Prototype: a link, repository or files; screenshots and a short recording are also acceptable if it only runs on your machine.
- Send your deck and prototype 24 hours before the session.

Tools and data

Use whatever tools you like. No licence is provided and no paid product is required; free tiers or basic tools are completely fine.

Using AI tools is encouraged. Tell us which tools you used, where and why. Your reasoning about tool choice counts.

> **Confidentiality**
> Use only public or self-created material. Do not use confidential information from any current or previous employer or customer.

60 MINUTES · VIDEO OR IN PERSON IN MADRID

The session

30 minutes	Your presentation: plan (A), live prototype demo (B) and closing vision (C). As a guide: approximately 10 / 15 / 5 minutes.
15 minutes	Questions from the panel on your presentation and prototype.
15 minutes	Open conversation: your questions to us, and ours to you.

Panel: Bao Huy Lam, Global Head of Solution Engineering CoE and hiring manager, together with a tenured DDN colleague. Please keep the presentation to 30 minutes; we will keep time.

What we look for

Builder mindset

You build and ship, not only design.

Field-first

Your plan starts from what SEs and account teams need to win.

AI fluency

Hands-on, practical use of AI, including its limits.

Scale-up resilience

Clear priorities and structure where no playbook exists yet.

Communication

Clear, concise and adapted to an executive audience.

Your work stays yours

Everything you prepare remains your property. DDN will use it only to evaluate your application and will not use it for any other purpose unless you join DDN or we agree otherwise in writing.

Questions?

Contact Aoife Buckley, Talent Acquisition, at abuckley@ddn.com. We are happy to clarify the brief, but the scoping decisions are yours.